

OVERCOMING LIFES HANDICAPS

TEXT: 2 Samuel 9:3-7 (NKJV) *"Then the king said, "Is there not still someone of the house of Saul, to whom I may show the kindness of God?" And Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, "There is still a son of Jonathan who is lame in his feet." 4 So the king said to him, "Where is he?" And Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, "Indeed he is in the house of Machir (Maw-keer) the son of Ammiel, in Lo Debar." 5 Then King David sent and brought him out of the house of Machir (Maw-keer) the son of Ammiel, from Lo Debar. 6 Now when Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, had come to David, he fell on his face and prostrated himself. Then David said, "Mephibosheth?" And he answered, "Here is your servant!" 7 So David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father's sake, and will restore to you all the land of Saul your grandfather; and you shall eat bread at my table continually."*

INTRO: The culture that we are forced to function in has subtly taught us, we should dumb down our dreams because we have been handicapped by the circumstances that surround our lives!

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

This culture say's that we should diminish our expectations if:

- We come from a single parent family...
- Our family of origin was dysfunctional ...
- We have a background of poverty...
- We could not afford an Ivy League education...

The world is full of examples of people overcoming handicaps in life through the help of God and a bountiful dose of determination; allow me to point out a few of them:

- (1) In 1996, Lance Armstrong was diagnosed with testicular cancer and informed that his career as a world class cyclist was over. Less than three years later, after successfully battling the disease, the determined athlete

proved the medical experts wrong by winning the grueling Tour de France. He has gone on to win the race six more times.

- (2) Joni Erickson Tada is the founder of Joni and Friends, an organization accelerating Christian ministry in the disability community.

A diving accident in 1967 left Mrs. Tada a quadriplegic in a wheelchair, unable to use her hands. During two years of rehabilitation, she spent long months learning how to paint with a brush between her teeth. Her high detail fine art paintings and prints are sought after and collected.

Mrs. Tada is now recognized by her first name in countries around the world following the distribution in many languages of her biography *Joni* and the full-length feature film JONI, in which she portrays her own life. She has personally visited over 41 countries, several of them many times.

Mrs. Tada's role as a disability advocate led to a three year and a half presidential appointment to the National Council on Disability, during which time the Americans with Disabilities Act became law.

Joni and Friends was founded by Mrs. Tada in 1979 and has grown into four flagship programs which affect the lives of thousands of disabled people and their families.

- With over a million listeners a week "*Joni and Friends*," a daily five minute radio program, is heard over more than 1000 broadcast outlets. In 2002 it received the "Radio Program of the Year" award from National Religious Broadcasters.
- In 2004 Joni and Friends served over 600 special need families through 13 *Family Retreats* across the nation.

- Through *Wheels for the World*, over 25,000 wheelchairs have been collected nationwide, refurbished by inmates in correctional facilities, and then shipped and donated to developing nations where, whenever possible, physical therapists fit each chair to a needy disabled child or adult.
- Through 11 *Area Ministry* offices nationwide, the Joni and Friends teams provide church training along with educational and inspirational resources to promote ministry to those affected by disability and those who can help.

On Friday, December 3, 2004, Joni and Friends broke ground for their new INTERNATIONAL DISABILITY CENTER. The IDC will not only accommodate the extraordinary growth of existing programs but provide a new communications center and training facility for international partnerships.

(3) Allow me to introduce you to the story of a handicapped evangelist, as told by Missionary Otto Koning, who spent his life ministering to the natives of New Guinea: A missionary gathered all the Christians from all over the country every year for a conference. At this conference they would sing and have preaching.

At one such conference the missionary stood and said, *“Men, there is enough of you Christians now. I can’t go any further to carry the Gospel, I’m getting old myself. You younger men must now go and take the Gospel across these ranges to the South and to the South parts of the mountains. I can’t do it anymore; you must now carry the message.”* Then he preached about the Great Commission, and at the invitation, 21 young men stepped out of this huge gathering and said, *“We will take the Gospel South of the Ranges.”*

This would not be an easy task as there were many tribes in the mountains who killed all foreigners or strangers who traveled past their villages.

The last of the twenty-one young men was a severely handicapped man. His legs were totally useless. One leg had the knee locked in a kneeling position and the other leg was bent underneath him, he actually sat on that leg and couldn't move it. He would propel himself by taking a pointed stick and digging it into the dirt and pull himself towards that stick. Then he would half jump, half drag himself 8 inches at a time.

That's how he came down the isle to volunteer to go across the Ranges to be a missionary. Everyone shook their heads and said, *"No way. You'll die of exposure on those mountains; you won't be able to cross them fast enough. You'll run out of food on the way."* And then somebody said, *"When those dangerous people come chasing you, you won't be able to get away and they will kill you."* So they told him he should not go.

The other twenty turned and prepared to go over the mountains. This man was disappointed, but God was dealing with him in such a way that he couldn't sleep. He just had to go. One day, knowing that the people would probably stop him or discourage him, he set out early. When his friends realized he was gone, they wondered what had happened to him.

He set out toward the mountain ranges in the South, eight inches at a time, hobbling along. He had a bag with some food and a knife with him, but most importantly he had a Gospel Booklet. It took this man more than thirty days to cross the mountain ranges; he almost died of exposure; he ran out of food so he ate roots, berries and leaves. He prayed and begged God to help him. He was at the point of death when he came down the south side of the ranges.

When the natives found him, surprisingly, they decided not to kill him. Instead, they carried him to the house of the chief of the village. There, all the warriors of the village sat around him and listened to his stories. They gave him the best of everything they had. They nursed him back to health! When the time came, he led those natives, one after another to Jesus.

A year went by and it was time for the Christian Conference to be held so he told them they had to go to the Conference where all the Christians gather. 250 of his converts carried him across the mountains. Finally when they approached the Conference, and saw the masses of Christians there, singing and praising God, he said, *"Now I want you to set me down, I will lead you to the Christians."* They sat him down and followed him, eight inches at a time. As they walked they were singing the songs he had taught them. When someone got up to speak at the Conference, and it got quiet, the Christians heard singing coming from the direction of the south range. When they turned their attention toward the direction of the singing they saw the handicapped evangelist dragging his legs and bringing his 250 converts to the Conference.

Each ensuing year the handicapped evangelist would bring all the Christians from his tribe to the Conference. Eventually there were thousands of converts from the tribe of the handicapped evangelist.

God wants us to know that no matter what kind of handicaps have enslaved us in the past; He offers freedom from all of life's handicaps! No matter what you face, God is bigger than your problems! I want you to see a video clip of an amazing story of determination to overcome one of life's great handicaps!
(SHOW THE VIDEO)

In an effort to learn how to overcome the things that hold us back from God's best, I want us to look at the story of a cripple

Prince by the name of Mephibosheth.

In this passage of Scripture David is King over Israel. The backdrop for this story involves David making a covenant, many years prior, with Jonathan, who was King Saul's son.

Saul wanted to kill David but Jonathan protected him (*The twisted culture we live in has made far more of this than was actually there*). This covenant came out of a friendship between David and Jonathan, which was solidified with Jonathan's loyalty to David when his King father was seeking the life of his friend.

In this passage of Scripture Saul and Jonathan are dead and David is King. Even though Jonathan, David's friend is dead, David remembers and honors the covenant between him and his friend. **Vs. 3** ***"Is there not still someone of the house of Saul, to whom I may show the kindness of God?"***

Notice here, all David asked was whether or not there was a surviving descendent of Saul with whom he could keep his covenant with Jonathan. Listen to the response of Ziba (Zee-baw), **Vs 3** ***"There is still a son of Jonathan who is lame in his feet."*** Notice Ziba (Zee-baw) remembers his shame before he remembers his name. The same is true of everyone in this audience; people will always remember our failures...

- He cheated on his wife...
- She was arrested for shoplifting...
- He used to be an alcoholic...
- She had an abortion...

Mephibosheth's problem was that he had been dropped. **2 Samuel 4:4 (NKJV)** ***"Jonathan, Saul's son, had a son who was lame in his feet. He was five years old when the news about Saul and Jonathan came from Jezreel; and his nurse took him up and fled. And it happened, as she made haste to flee, that he fell and became lame. His name was Mephibosheth."***

The world is full of people who have been dropped. The church is full of people who have been dropped. The church has been guilty of dropping a lot of people!

From the time his nurse dropped him Mephibosheth could never shake his history. No matter where he went or what he did his history ruled the day. He couldn't get away from his past. His legs were a constant reminder to him.

There are people in this audience today that would love to escape their past but everywhere they go it seems to arrive before they do.

Look at this, in one day Mephibosheth went from Prince to Pauper; from fortune to unfortunate; from destined to destitute; from complete to cripple; from capable to incapable! Have you ever had a thing like this happen to you? One day you feel as if you have the world by the tail on a down hill pull and the next day all opportunity has evaporated.

Mephibosheth believed his handicap had to do with his legs but in reality, his legs were only a symptom of what was really wrong. His real handicap was that:

I. HE WAS IN THE WRONG PLACE AT THE WRONG TIME...

A. The problem here was not as much with the condition of Mephibosheth as it was with his position.

The real problem that Mephibosheth faced was that he was out of place. He was bred and born for a palace, not the ghetto! That is precisely the problem with many of us. We are not in the right place.

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

We are:

- Heirs of God...
- Joint Heirs with Jesus...

- A Holy Nation...
- A Royal Priesthood...
- A Chosen Generation...
- A Peculiar People...
- Set Apart for the Work of God...

God commanded Elijah to go to the Brook Cherith and He would sustain him THERE. If Elijah had gone anywhere else, he would have starved to death. He had to be in the right place at the right time! (*Israel: Under the Cloud and Fire... Because of this, A Rock followed them*)

B. All the enemy has to do is keep us out of place! When we are not where we need to be, when we are supposed to be there, we miss out on the provision of God!

Mephibosheth was in the house of Machir (Maw-keer). By all accounts, Machir (Maw-keer) treats Mephibosheth very well, but his resources and ability are very limited.

If you are not in the right place at the right time the thing that blessed you yesterday can keep you from a blessing today. Eventually, Elijah's brook dried up!

It is not difficult to leave those who are your enemies or who mistreat you, but sometimes you have to leave your friends. Some friends have gone as far as they can go with you but they are not going to the place of your destiny! You have to break out and go it alone if necessary! (*Old song: "I have decided to follow Jesus"... One verse say's "Though none go with me, still I will follow"...*)

C. Machir (Maw-keer) is a place of survival, a land of just enough! God wants to take you to a place of plenty, the land of more than enough!

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

For Israel:

- Egypt was a land of never enough...
- The wilderness was a land of just enough...
- Canaan was a land of more than enough...

If Mephibosheth could see ahead to the King's palace, he would have no problem leaving the house of Machir (Maw-keer). The problem is we cannot see everything God has in store for us until we move out by faith.

II. HE WAS BEING NEGATIVELY IMPACTED BY A LACK OF INFORMATION...

A. David found Mephibosheth living in the city of Lo Debar.

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

The word Lo Debar comes from two Hebrew words and is defined in the following ways:

- Lo - meaning "No"
- Debar - meaning "Word"

When you combine those two words it simply means "***No Word.***" Mephibosheth was living in the land of "***No Word.***"

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

Mephibosheth knew nothing of:

- The Covenant...
- The promise...
- The revelation...
- The blessing...

B. Just because Mephibosheth didn't know about the covenant did not void it. The covenant was good, valid, and current! Mephibosheth just needed to get himself into a place of being made aware of, and accepting it by faith. *(Example of people having money being held for them but not being aware of it)*

There are people in this place today who are living a sub-par existence but God has greater things in mind. The reason we are not there is because we have been living in the land of "***No***

Word!" I have a word for you, "GET UP CRIPPLE PRINCE AND MAKE YOUR WAY TOWARD THE PALACE!"

C. Notice the response of Mephibosheth to all that David told him... **2 Samuel 9:8 (NKJV)** ***"Then he bowed himself, and said, "What is your servant, that you should look upon such a dead dog as I?"***

Mephibosheth was not just putting himself down he was speaking against the covenant! When the Syrophenician woman came to Jesus, He told her it was not right to **"give the children's bread to dogs."** What Jesus was saying was, you have no place or covenant. This is what Mephibosheth is saying... **"I have no place, or covenant."** We must be able to see ourselves within the boundaries of the covenant before we can get there.

III. HE COULD NOT VISUALIZE HIMSELF BEING BLESSED...

A. **2 Samuel 9:5-7 (NKJV)** ***"Then King David sent and brought him out of the house of Machir (Maw-keer) the son of Ammiel (Am-mee-el), from Lo Debar. 6 Now when Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, had come to David, he fell on his face and prostrated himself Then David said, "Mephibosheth?" And he answered, "Here is your servant!" 7 So David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father's sake, and will restore to you all the land of Saul your grandfather; and you shall eat bread at my table continually."***

David went looking for Mephibosheth; Mephibosheth did not go looking for David. You did not come here today expecting to be brought out of your situation but God is here today to bring you into His destiny for you! He always takes the first step; He is the initiator of the covenant.

B. When Mephibosheth became aware of the covenant and the fact that David was about to bring him out of Lo Debar and the house of Machir (Maw-keer) he humbled himself before the

King; he bowed down! No person with a physical defect was supposed to come into the presence of the king.

Many believe that they must get their lives straightened out before they can come to God but God desires for you to come to him just as you are. He wants to bring you out of your condition!

David bent the rules for Mephibosheth. We may not be qualified to come in... BUT GOD!!!

C. 2 Samuel 9:7 (NKJV) “*I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father’s sake...*” As it turns out this is not about Mephibosheth at all, it was about David’s covenant with Jonathan!

Mephibosheth claims to be a “***A dead dog***” and David never contradicts him. For David, it was not about who Mephibosheth was; it was about his friend Jonathan!

You may not feel worthy to be brought out of your condition to be brought into the promise, which is alright, because none of us are worthy!

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

Everything we have received is because of Jesus!

- God has blessed us for Jesus sake!
- Our salvation is a result of His blood!
- Our healing is a result of His stripes!
- Our peace is a result of His suffering!
- Our destiny is a result of His victory! (Eph. 1&2 “... ***God raised Jesus from the dead and set Him at His own right hand, far above... You also hath He quickened...***)

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

2 Samuel 9:7 (NKJV):

- The covenant involved provision! “...***I will restore to***

you all the land of Saul your grandfather...”

- The covenant involved fellowship with princes and the King! “...*you shall eat bread at my table continually.*”

I can imagine all those who ate at David’s table...

- AMNON - Young and strong!
- ABSALOM - The Bible says that from head to toe there was not a blemish on him!
- TAMAR - Historians say perhaps the most beautiful woman of her day!
- ABIATHAR - A loyal priest to David!
- NATHAN - A prophet of God!
- SOLOMON - Wisest man who ever lived!
- DAVID – The greatest King in the history of the world!
- Then, MEPHIBOSHETH!

SONG: “*I’m so glad I’m a part of the family of God*”